

House Hunt — Neighborhood Comparison

Personal. Planning a first home purchase in the next 18 to 24 months. Nothing to do with the practice.

What I am optimizing for

- Total price in the 250k to 340k range, so the payment stays sane on one income.
- A commute to the Columbus office under about 30 minutes on in-office days.
- Quiet streets, a decent window for morning light, and room for a small reading nook.
- A neighborhood I would still like in five years, not just a deal.

Neighborhood comparison

Neighborhood	Median price	Commute	Schools	Vibe	Note
Westerville (current)	\$310k	25 min	strong	familiar	know it, like it, a touch pricey
Worthington	\$335k	30 min	excellent	polished	great schools, over budget
Gahanna	\$285k	22 min	good	newer	good value, newer builds
Clintonville	\$340k	18 min	good	walkable	walkable, very competitive
Grove City	\$265k	35 min	fair	suburban	cheapest, longest drive
New Albany	\$430k	28 min	excellent	upscale	out of budget, aspirational only
Dublin	\$390k	30 min	excellent	corporate	stretch, nice but pricey
Hilliard	\$300k	27 min	good	family	solid middle option

Rough monthly at 6.5% on a 30-year, 10% down

Price	Loan	Est. P&I	Plus tax+ins (est.)	All-in est.
\$265k	\$238k	\$1,505	~\$450	~\$1,955
\$285k	\$256k	\$1,620	~\$490	~\$2,110
\$310k	\$279k	\$1,765	~\$540	~\$2,305
\$335k	\$301k	\$1,905	~\$580	~\$2,485

Where I am leaning

Gahanna on value, Clintonville if I want walkable and can win a bidding war, Westerville if I just want to stay put. None of this happens until the emergency fund is topped up and I see where the practice lands financially. This is a next-year decision at the earliest.

To do eventually: get pre-qualified, walk a few Gahanna listings, check property tax rates by district. Not urgent.

Criteria weighting (how I am really deciding)

Criterion	Weight	Why
Monthly payment sanity	30%	one income, must not stretch
Commute	20%	three in-office days a week
Neighborhood I will still like	20%	not just chasing a deal
Schools / resale	15%	resale even without kids now
Move-in condition	15%	low appetite for a big reno

Top three, pros and cons

Gahanna.

- For: best value in budget, newer builds, shortest of the affordable commutes.
- Against: fewer walkable options, a little further from friends in the north and Short North.

Clintonville.

- For: walkable, close in, character, easy to see myself here.
- Against: top of budget, competitive market, likely a bidding war and compromises on size.

Westerville (stay).

- For: I know it, I like it, zero learning curve, close to the running loop.
- Against: a touch pricey for what you get, and part of me wants a genuine fresh start.

Timeline

- This is a next-year decision at the earliest, after the emergency fund is topped up.
- Step one is getting pre-qualified so I know the real number, not a Zillow guess.
- No offers until I see how the practice lands and whether income steadies.

Nothing here is urgent and none of it touches work or the practice. Just keeping my thinking in one place.